

Study Questions: Perception — Reading the Room While You Stitch

1. How does social perception in a crochet circle differ from the physical perception of managing your own stitches? In what ways are they similar as Active Inference processes?
2. Describe the **generative model** you hold for a specific person in your circle (real or imagined). What predictions does your model make about their behavior at a typical meeting?
3. When Rosa suddenly stops humming and puts down her hook, this generates a **prediction error**. Explain why this silence is more noticeable than James pausing yet again.
4. What are the key **auditory signals** in a crochet circle's shared sensory environment? How does the sound landscape change between a relaxed meeting and a tense one?
5. How does **conversation rhythm** serve as a perceptual signal? What does it mean when the circle goes quiet during a complicated stitch section versus when it goes quiet after someone shares personal news?
6. Explain how **peripheral vision** allows a crocheter to monitor the social environment while focused on their own work. What information does visual perception provide about other members' states?
7. What is the **emotional atmosphere** of a room, and how does a circle member perceive it? How does this relate to hierarchical inference in Active Inference?
8. How does the concept of **precision** in Active Inference apply to social perception in the circle? Why do your predictions about familiar members have higher precision than predictions about a newcomer?
9. Describe the behavioral signatures of **flow** in a crocheter. Why is it important for circle members to recognize flow in others?

10. Describe the behavioral signatures of **frustration** in a crocheter. How does the perceiving member decide whether to offer help or stay quiet?
11. A beginner crocheter has little attentional capacity left over for social perception because their hands demand so much focus. Explain this in terms of **precision weighting** and attentional allocation.
12. Think about a time you **misread** someone's state in a social setting (crochet circle or otherwise). How did the prediction error you experienced update your generative model of that person?
13. How does the **sound of frogging** (ripping out stitches) function as a social signal in the circle? What predictions does it trigger in other members?
14. A new member joins the circle for the first time. What is the **precision** of your predictions about their behavior? How does this low precision affect your attentional allocation toward them?
15. Compare the social perception of a circle that has met for years with one that has just formed. How do the generative models of long-standing members differ from those of new acquaintances?
16. How does **active perception** work in a social context? Give an example of a circle member actively seeking information about another's state (rather than passively receiving it).
17. In a virtual crochet circle (video call), what perceptual channels are available and what is lost compared to in-person? How does this affect social inference?
18. How does the ability to perceive social signals while stitching develop over time? What role does **automaticity** in the physical task play?
19. Some circle members are highly attuned to the room while others seem oblivious. What might account for these differences in social perception from an Active Inference perspective?

20. Reflect on the idea that social perception in a circle is what transforms "a group of people crocheting in the same room" into "a community." What does perception contribute that physical proximity alone does not?